learned in the Second Lebanon War in 2006 that Hezbollah fighters are fierce combatants, and the organization has since accumulated a huge arsenal of long-range, precision-guided missiles provided by its patron, Iran. The fighters themselves have garnered considerable battle experience in civil wars in Syria and Yemen. Hezbollah, on the other hand, realizes that the Israeli Air Force alone can rain destruction on southern Lebanon, and knows quite well the force the IDF can unleash on the ground. In short, both sides have good reason to remain cautious for as long as possible. This said, if a two-front war were to take place, Israel could win it even without American military support, though it would undoubtedly take a long time, entail enormous devastation, and exact an unthinkably high human toll.

It is difficult to know whether, in the wake of October 7, Israelis have lost some of the confidence they had in the army, even in difficult times. After the Yom Kippur War, there was a need to pin responsibility on some of the senior commanders. An investigative body, the Agranat Commission, dismissed chief of staff David Elazar, head of military intelligence Eli Zeira, and the initial commander of the southern front, Shmuel “Gorodish” Gonen, among others, yet shielded the political figures who supposedly made bad decisions on the basis of bad information, mainly Golda Meir and Moshe Dayan. One has the feeling, and this will undoubtedly become clearer in due time, that the present crisis of confidence is worse. This must be taken into account in any planning for prolonged fighting. But of course, Hamas and Hezbollah know this.

In the South, Egypt has not yet allowed the opening of the Rafah border crossing into Gaza through which humanitarian aid will eventually pass, because it wants only Palestinians with dual citizenship to use the crossing. In other words, the Egyptians are worried about a massive Palestinian exodus through the Rafah crossing into their country. “They should settle in the Negev,” president of Egypt Abdel Fattah el-Sisi is alleged to have said.